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Source: *19th-Century Music*, Vol. 3, No. 3 (Mar., 1980), pp. 251-258

Published by: [University of California Press](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/746489>

Accessed: 17/06/2014 12:26

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Frei aber Froh: A Reconsideration

MICHAEL MUSGRAVE

One of the most intriguing aspects of nineteenth-century German "absolute" music is the role played by ciphers and motto themes: that is, either ideas whose constituent notes spell out or represent words, or ideas which, though inspired initially by texts, now stand alone and give no hint of their origin. By its very nature the subject is remarkably prone to conjecture and, probably for this reason, has generally discouraged the serious investigation it deserves. My purpose here is not to offer new examples of such ideas, but rather to cast doubt on the authenticity of one of the most widely accepted of them—Brahms's motto "*Frei aber froh*," generally translated as "Free but happy." This is not the first challenge mounted against this motto; Henry Drinker pointed out as early

as 1933 that none of Brahms's biographers had advanced it on the authority of the composer himself, or of Joachim, from whose own device, "*Frei aber einsam*" ("Free but lonely"), it was assumed to have evolved.¹ That Drinker's remarks have had no significant influence is clear, however, from the continuing currency of the motto.² It now seems timely to present a more extensive consideration than the fragmentary and rather dismissive remarks which he makes.³

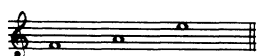
¹Henry S. Drinker, *The Chamber Music of Johannes Brahms* (Philadelphia, 1932; rpt. Westport, Conn., 1974), p. 96.

²See, for example, Peter Latham, *Brahms* (1948; rev. ed. London, 1975), pp. 101–02; *The New Encyclopaedia Britannica in 30 Volumes* (Chicago, 1976), XVII, p. 916; and Bernard Jacobson, *The Music of Johannes Brahms* (London, 1977), p. 163.

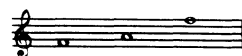
³Drinker, *Chamber music*, pp. 38–39, 82.

All the writers who acknowledge an origin for their reference to "*Frei aber froh*" cite the same source, Brahms's "official" biography by Max Kalbeck. Yet nowhere in the passage in question does Kalbeck provide any direct evidence that Brahms ever mentioned the motto. Rather it is introduced in the course of a very picturesque account of Brahms's journey through the Rhine Valley in the summer of 1853:⁴

Brahms had taken it into his head to wander from the Middle Rhine down through the magnificent river valley like a traveling artisan, with a pack on his back and a knobbled stick in his fist; and he carried out this plan in full consciousness of the growing power of his youth. He desired from nature only the pleasure of earning by the sweat of his own brow, pleasure which she held out to him in plenty. Since he was traveling unaccompanied, he had adopted Joachim's mournful motto, "*Frei aber einsam*," the musical expression of which contains a pure fifth reminiscent of the violin:



The most frugal meal or the poorest night's lodging, which a more fastidious person would have despised, suited him perfectly. And he may have passed many warm, starlit summer nights dreaming rather than sleeping in the shade of an old linden tree, or near Ludwig Uhland's "*Wirte, wundermild*,"⁵ where the water nymphs of the green streams sang him their slumber songs. Thinking of the precious enslavement of society, he inverted the motto of his friend and wrote a heartfelt "Lonely but free" ("*Einsam aber frei*") on his banner; or, by raising the fifth to the sixth degree he sang out to the fresh morning a jubilant and harmonious "Free but happy" ("*Frei aber froh*"). It is no accident that the octave divided by a third, or more often by an inverted third, became one of the principal motives in Brahms's music. We encounter the idea



in a variety of transformations and disguises, from its first clear appearance in the Second Ballade (op. 10) up through the Third Symphony, which grew directly out of it. It serves him for the expression of both the highest bliss and the deepest sorrow, and sounds secretly in many portions of his works.

Taken as it stands, this passage provides scant justification for the validity of the motto. While the origin of Joachim's motto is, of course, well established,⁶ that of Brahms appears to rest on this fanciful passage alone. How could it have been accepted as reliable by subsequent writers? The only immediate explanation lies in the great prestige that Kalbeck's biography has generally enjoyed. It was intended to become, and has remained, the most comprehensive work on the composer, gaining the stamp of authority from the personal contact of its author with his subject, to say nothing of the number of friends and acquaintances consulted in its preparation; by the second edition Kalbeck had acknowledged the help of no less than 127 contributors. Even though at times the book seems richer in poetry than in scholarship, it is hardly surprising that readers should have continued to regard its contents as essentially trustworthy. That Kalbeck in the present instance provides no precise documentation for his assertion need not preclude the possibility that he derived the information from Brahms himself, or from one of his most closely-informed contributors. There is, in the final analysis, no means of challenging such a view. At the same time, it leaves us without the kind of evidence necessary if the motto is to be accepted with

⁴Max Kalbeck, *Johannes Brahms*, 2nd edn. (Berlin, 1908–16), I, 98.

⁵This is a reference to Uhland's poem "*Einkehr*," which obviously inspired some of the imagery of the passage. It begins: "*Bei einem Wirte wundermild / Da war ich jüngst zu Gaste / Ein goldner Apfel war sein Schild / An einem langen Aste.*" See *Uhlands Werke*, ed. Ludwig Fränkel (Leipzig and Vienna, 1893), I, 52. See also *The Oxford Book of German Verse* (Oxford, 1911), p. 246.

⁶Joachim explained the significance of "*Frei aber einsam*" to Schumann in a letter of 29 November 1853. The motto was prompted by Joachim's personal situation, indicating that he wished to be married, but remained, reluctantly, single. Kalbeck makes no reference to this point, about which he would not, presumably, have known when he wrote the above passage, in view of the date of publication of Joachim's correspondence. See *Briefe von und an Joseph Joachim*, ed. Johannes Joachim and Andreas Moser, 3 vols. (Berlin, 1911–13), I, 109.

confidence. In my view, sufficient doubt can be cast on the extent of Kalbeck's intimacy with Brahms so as to render the lack of documentation a significant obstacle.⁷

Although the regular acquaintance which Kalbeck claims⁸ can be confirmed by the writings of others in Brahms's circle—most notably Billroth, Hanslick, and Heuberger—there is no evidence that Kalbeck was ever really close to Brahms. Hanslick cites himself and Billroth as Brahms's closest friends in Vienna,⁹ and Kalbeck's distance would seem confirmed in the very limited nature of his correspondence with the composer, both compared with these two and with Brahms's other Viennese friends.¹⁰ After criticizing Kalbeck's early work,¹¹ Brahms certainly came to accept his skills as critic and poet,¹² yet he obviously maintained reservations. Both Heuberger and Specht show Brahms refuting remarks by Kalbeck, Specht laying particular stress on the

sharpness of Brahms's reaction to Kalbeck's often brash comments, especially those concerning Wagner.¹³ However, a remark of Brahms's noted by Heuberger suggests that his reservations were perhaps of a more fundamental nature: "Recently Brahms spoke of Kalbeck and said he thought that he did not possess the inner discretion without which no one can achieve anything outstanding."¹⁴ Unfortunately, Heuberger offers no explanation for the remark. This attitude of Brahms's, with the composer's considerable reticence in revealing the background to his music, makes it seem very unlikely that he would have imparted something as important as the identity of his personal motto to Kalbeck rather than to his closest friends. Moreover, had Kalbeck been the recipient, he would surely have made the most of the circumstances, rather than allowing the information to pass on without comment in the course of describing events which had happened years before he had known Brahms.

If Brahms did not recall the invention of the motto to Kalbeck at some stage during their acquaintance, then no one else seems to have done so, for Kalbeck was remarkably dependent upon the recollections of Brahms's friends for details of the early period.¹⁵ None of them makes any reference to "*Frei aber froh*"; neither in the published reminiscences and volumes of correspondence which began to appear after Brahms's death, nor in any subsequent sources of this kind, are any references to be found. One naturally looks to the correspondence with Joachim with particular interest, not least since the friends frequently exchanged contrapuntal exercises, some involving mottoes. There are several references to "F-A-E" and one to "GISELA,"¹⁶ but none

⁷Few scholars have questioned this relationship. In the most recent comprehensive survey in English of Brahms source research, the late Donald M. McCorkle pointed out the documentary limitations of Kalbeck's biography but perpetuated the view that Kalbeck was "a close friend [of Brahms] for about twenty-three years." See "Five Fundamental Obstacles in Brahms Source Research," *Acta Musicologica* 47 (1976), 258–59.

⁸Kalbeck I, iv.

⁹Eduard Hanslick, *Aus meinem Leben* (Berlin, 1894), II, 94.

¹⁰ Although the extent of Brahms's correspondence with Kalbeck has yet to be investigated, the indications are that it was slight. In the Schneider Catalogue, which lists a large part of the Kalbeck Nachlass, Brahms's contribution is limited to a handful of communications, mostly brief messages of a social nature on cards. Kalbeck's efforts were greater, comprising twelve letters and two cards. See *Musikantiquariat Hans Schneider, Katalog No. 100—Johannes Brahms* (Tutzing, 1964), pp. 31–41, 75. Five further letters from Kalbeck to Brahms are held by the Wiener Stadtbibliothek. Although Kalbeck does quote a few letters from Brahms in his biography, it seems likely that he would have published them in full had the correspondence been of any substance, especially given his extensive editorial work on Brahms's correspondence with others. By contrast, the correspondence with Theodor Billroth is very extensive, even allowing for their longer acquaintance. See *Brahms und Billroth im Briefwechsel*, ed. O. Gottlieb-Billroth (Berlin and Vienna, 1935). Although there is no official "Briefwechsel" with Hanslick, he quotes from a number of letters from Brahms in *Am Ende des Jahrhunderts*, 2nd edn. (Berlin, 1899), pp. 372–409, indicating that these are only a selection from a larger correspondence.

¹¹*Briefwechsel* III, 226.

¹²Brahms set two of Kalbeck's poems: "Nachtwandler," op. 86, no. 3, and "Letztes Glück," op. 104, no. 3.

¹³Richard Specht, *Johannes Brahms* (Hellenau, 1928), pp. 205–10.

¹⁴Richard Heuberger, *Erinnerungen an Johannes Brahms* (Tutzing, 1971), p. 146.

¹⁵Kalbeck I, iv–v.

¹⁶*Briefwechsel* V, 136–37, 143. "Gisela," written *Gis-e-a* (G#–E–A), represented Gisela von Arnim, daughter of Bettina von Arnim (Bettina Brentano), and a youthful friend of Brahms and Joachim. Brahms stresses the relationship between G#–E–A and F–A–E, of which it is a mirror form.

to "F-A-F." Nor do the nineteen *Neugierige Fragen* answered by Joachim for Kalbeck offer any confirmation.¹⁷ It is particularly interesting in this context to note a remark by another youthful intimate, Dietrich, in the more extensive *Fragebogen* which he completed for Kalbeck, a document whose contents give a very clear indication of the nature of the biographer's dependence on his contributors.¹⁸ Kalbeck specifically asks Dietrich whether any mottoes other than those that Dietrich had already mentioned in his published reminiscences are to be found in Brahms's chamber and orchestral works. Dietrich replies in the negative.¹⁹ However, perhaps the most significant omission is from the one source where Brahms would certainly have noted anything of this kind, namely *Des Jungen Kreislers Schatzkästlein*, the notebook in which the young composer recorded all his favorite literary quotations.²⁰ It shows the particular strength of the composer's relation to Joachim in a number of passages, his motto appearing as "Frei aber einsam," "F-A-E," or written in musical notation. But there is no reference at all to "Frei aber froh." While it is of course pos-

sible that fresh material may throw new light on the matter, it seems reasonable on the basis of the known facts to conclude that "Frei aber froh" was not the invention of Brahms but of Kalbeck.

Support for this conclusion can be found in the six instances of the motto's use cited by Kalbeck. Of these, he focuses the greatest attention on passages from the Third Symphony and the Second String Quartet, though for different reasons. The opening of the Third Symphony provides the most oft-quoted example of "Frei aber froh" in Brahms's music. Here the motive F-A $\flat$ -F appears first in the upper parts, then in the bass, supporting the descending theme of the violins. While there is no question of the pervasive influence of this motive throughout the work as a whole, its relation to Kalbeck's "Frei aber froh" seems tenuous in view of the alteration of the third. The whole point of "Frei aber froh" would seem to lie in its mood of optimism; the change from A to A $\flat$ hardly expresses this mood. There is, indeed, no need to argue the point since Kalbeck draws attention to it himself, suggesting that the motive might even escape the listener's attention because of this modification, and because the violin theme claims the largest share of our attention. His explanation, however, fails to offer any broader interpretation of the meaning of the motto, but merely argues that Brahms was trying to obscure its identity: "F-A $\flat$ -F takes care of the incognito."²¹ Were the authenticity of the motto established, this view might be acceptable, but it cannot be used to establish any independent viewpoint.

While the motive F-A $\flat$ -F in the Symphony is very frequently associated with "Frei aber froh," the link with the opening of the Quartet has been questioned²² because Kalbeck is forced to rearrange its constituent notes.²³ He sees F-A-F as having been changed to A-F-A, the new form being dovetailed into Joachim's F-A-E to open the principal theme of the first movement (see ex. 1).

¹⁷Max Kalbeck, *Neugierige Fragen eines wissendurigen Brahms Biographien. Beantwort von Josef Joachim* (Vienna and Berlin, 1901). This document comprises four closely-written sides in a format similar to the Dietrich *Fragebogen* (see below). See also Schneider, *Brahms Katalog*, p. 75. The *Fragebogen* is now in the possession of the Staats- und Universitätsbibliothek, Hamburg. While it does not mention "Frei aber froh," it does confirm the authenticity of the "Agathe" motto (notated A-G-A-B-E), a reference to Agathe von Siebold, another friend from Brahms's youth, providing Kalbeck with the musical example that he reproduces in vol. II of the biography, p. 154.

¹⁸Max Kalbeck, *Fragebogen für Herrn Hofkapellmeister Albert Dietrich*. See Schneider, pp. 11-18, reproduced partly in facsimile, p. 96, facing. Kalbeck's thirty-five questions to Dietrich are all based on Dietrich's "Reminiscences," through which he works systematically in order to clarify and elaborate its contents, stating at the outset that the book had been a fundamental source for the biography. See Albert Dietrich, *Erinnerungen an Johannes Brahms* (Leipzig, 1898).

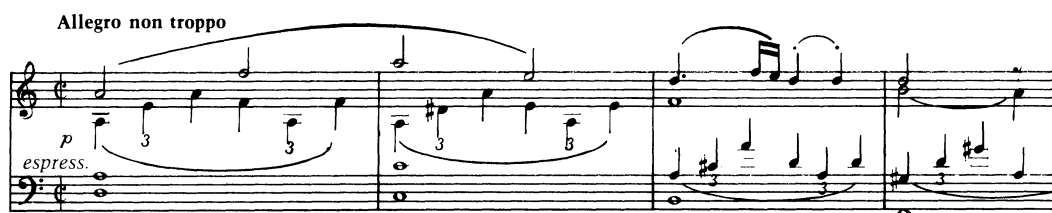
¹⁹Schneider, p. 14. Dietrich refers only to "F-A-E" and to the suppressed texts from the Sonatas, ops. 1 and 2: "Mein Herz ist im Hochland" (finale of the C-Major Sonata, op. 1) and "Mir ist leide dass der Winter beide" (slow movement of the F $\sharp$ -Minor Sonata, op. 2).

²⁰*Des Jungen Kreislers Schatzkästlein* (*The Treasure Chest of the Young Kreisler*), ed. C. Krebs (Berlin, 1909).

²¹Kalbeck III, 387-88.

²²See William G. Hill, "Brahms's Op. 51—A Diptych," *Music Review* 13 (1952), 110.

²³Kalbeck II, 444.



Example 1

One is strongly inclined to dismiss this as fanciful conjecture. However, while this rearrangement of the notes would seem to represent an unacceptable transformation of the motto for which they stand, Brahms does provide precedents for the free use of a motto, and it is of relevance at this juncture to outline briefly some notable examples. Of the five instances of F–A–E in *Des Jungen Kreislers Schatzkästelin*, one—though not omitting or repeating a note as in this case—does in fact rearrange the notes to read F–E–A²⁴ (see ex. 2).



Example 2

Furthermore, Brahms's Scherzo movement from the composite F–A–E Sonata treats the motto very freely; indeed, its opening gives no indication of the association at all²⁵ (see ex. 3).

Violin

Allegro

Piano

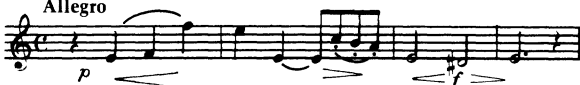
Example 3

²⁴*Des Jungen Kreislers Schatzkästlein*, no. 225, p. 57.

²⁵*F–A–E Sonata*, edited and critically revised by Erich Valentin and Otto Kobin (Magdeburg, 1935).

The link is rather via the first movement of the Sonata, composed by Dietrich, who states that Brahms drew on one of its motives.²⁶ Although he does not specify a precise location, a clear relation exists between his opening theme and Brahms's second theme (m. 32), one that follows Dietrich's outline closely. This relationship is paralleled even more closely in the rhythmic character of its sequel (m. 54) (see ex. 4).

(a) Dietrich
Allegro



(b) Brahms
Allegro m. 32



m. 54



Example 4

The emphasis which Dietrich's theme places on the notes E and F at the expense of A, the semitone interval dominating the theme and clearly influencing the second Brahms example, may provide a clue to the derivation of Brahms's first theme, where the insistent progression E–F in the piano may perhaps have prompted the more striking progression G–A $\flat$ in both piano and violin. Between them, Dietrich's theme and Brahms's apparent derivation permeate the entire movement. Again, if the motto "*Frei aber froh*" were authenticated, one could in principle sympathize with Kalbeck's identification of its role in the opening theme of the Quartet and pursue its influence more broadly. Lacking such a basis, however, it is rather the treatment of F–A–E which claims our loyalty.

With regard to Kalbeck's remaining examples of F–A–F, the opening theme of the Bal-

lade, op. 10—which employs F $\sharp$ –A–F $\sharp$ —may be classed with the example from the Third Symphony as using the minor rather than the major third, although, by virtue of its different relation to the tonic triad, it still expresses a major chord²⁷ (see ex. 5).

Andante



Example 5

The passage from mm. 26–31 of the first movement of the D-Minor Piano Concerto presents an analogous example, though appearing in the course of a theme in D minor²⁸ (see ex. 6).

Allegro



Example 6

The main theme of the Tragic Overture can be seen as relating, in its use of interpolation, to the second theme of the Scherzo from the F–A–E Sonata, though producing the much simpler progression A–C–F–A²⁹ (see ex. 7).

Allegro ma non troppo



Example 7

²⁶Dietrich, *Erinnerungen an Johannes Brahms*, p. 5.

²⁷Kalbeck I, 98.

²⁸Ibid.

²⁹Kalbeck III, 387.

The passage from the first movement of the First Symphony (mm. 21–24 of the introduction), stands apart from previous examples in transposing the motto—or rather its inverted shape—in its entirety³⁰ (see ex. 8).



Example 8

The principal theme of the following Allegro presents Kalbeck's only example of the motto in its correct form with a major third, although still without the correct pitch classes³¹ (see ex. 9).



Example 9

His failure to discuss the seemingly crucial semantic implications of changes in the constituent notes of the motto is further evidence of the inadequacy of his treatment. Viewed overall, these examples provide no convincing evidence that Brahms ever made significant use of the motive F–A–F.

What factors may have contributed to Kalbeck's identifying "*Frei aber froh*" as Brahms's personal motto? That he should attach the greatest importance to the Third Symphony is entirely natural, since in no other work by Brahms is the function of a motive so clearly identified. However, Kalbeck was not simply impressed by the musical structure. He saw the work as a major peak in Brahms's development and, further, as an expression of the state of German civilization attained in the newly-unified Reich, also symbolized for Kalbeck by the Germania, the Niederwald Memorial

situated at Rudesheim on the Rhine.³² The poetic analogy between the symphony and the memorial was obviously prompted by the fact that Brahms had visited it just before completing the work. Given this view of the work's significance and the consequent extra-musical status of its dominant motive, it is not surprising that Kalbeck should have been struck by the relationship between the symphony's F–A $\flat$ –F and Joachim's F–A–E, a motto of proven significance to Brahms. That Kalbeck proceeds to recall that F–A–E formed the basis for F–A–F would seem to confirm this association in his mind. Kalbeck's reference to the Rhine in this passage also represents an important link in his reasoning, connecting the Germania at Rudesheim, and thus the Symphony, with the youthful journey which had first supposedly inspired the transformation of F–A–E to F–A–F.

Brahms needed only to follow the snaky course of the Rhine in order to travel into the Romantic land of his youth; and everywhere, from mountains and castles, fields and woods, clefts and crevices, resounded that enticing and magical greeting—the emblem of longing that he made the leitmotif of his art, after he had evolved it from Joachim's motto F–A–E.³³

That the journey back from youth had effected, in the Symphony, a modification of the motive which is at variance with its supposed meaning is never seriously discussed by Kalbeck. The reason is surely that no explanation is possible, since the two are in no way related; F–A $\flat$ –F is a musical motive, "*Frei aber froh*" a literary motto.

Kalbeck certainly recognized the importance to Brahms of an octave with interpolated third, because he stresses it when he first discusses the motto. But he does not make an adequate distinction between the major and minor forms of the third, leaving the impression that they are interchangeable and that F–A–F will therefore serve as the simplest form, ripe for a literary motto. This simplification merely serves to cloud the issue, since Kalbeck can present no example of the simple F–A–F motive and is even forced to admit that

³⁰Ibid., p. 95.

³¹Kalbeck I, 237.

³²Kalbeck III, 385–86.

³³Ibid.

it is rather the modified third which is significant. One is therefore left to question why Kalbeck chose to make an issue of a literary motto, invented by himself, none of whose supposed manifestations is without significant modification, while paying no attention to the broader features of Brahms's thematic idiom which his examples illustrate.

The explanation for Kalbeck's pronounced selectivity with regard to the many pitches at which these characteristic shapes appear lies in his desire to give expression, in musical and literary terms equally, to the youthful relationship between Brahms and Joachim. Kalbeck rightly sees F–A–E as a symbol of their friendship. Although his view as to the fusion of their mottoes at the beginning of the Second Quartet seems fanciful, it nonetheless expresses a truth: namely, as Kalbeck explains in the sup-

porting text, that Brahms was greatly dependent upon Joachim in the consolidation of his earliest achievements, especially in writing string quartets.³⁴ Although F–A–F has no established foundation as a musical motto in Brahms's work, the idea it represents—that of Brahms's close relation with Joachim, yet, by virtue of his abilities, his independence—seems wholly acceptable. To what extent, however, such an imaginative approach to the interpretation of Brahms's works and their stimuli may have distorted the selection and discussion of Kalbeck's material for the biography is an interesting question. Doubt has often been cast on the accuracy of his statements and the reliability of his sources.³⁵ That some clarification is needed would seem confirmed by the background of "*Frei aber froh*."



³⁴Kalbeck II, 444.

³⁵See fn. 7.